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United States Patent	12401330
Kind Code	B2
Date of Patent	August 26, 2025
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Audio circuit

Abstract

A class D amplifier circuit receives an analog audio signal with a first reference voltage as its center level, and outputs an output pulse signal having a duty cycle that corresponds to the analog audio signal. A bias circuit generates a second reference voltage having a voltage level obtained as a division of the first reference voltage and the power supply voltage. A periodic voltage generating circuit of the class D amplifier circuit generates a periodic voltage having a triangle waveform or otherwise a sawtooth waveform having an amplitude that corresponds to the second reference voltage.

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Appl. No.:	18/193171
Filed:	March 30, 2023

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20230238926 A1	Jul. 27, 2023

Foreign Application Priority Data

JP	2020-166165	Sep. 30, 2020
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Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc WO PCT/JP2021/031523 20210827 PENDING child-doc US 18193171

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: **H03F3/00** (20060101); **H03F3/217** (20060101); **H03F3/45** (20060101); **H03K4/06** (20060101); **H03K5/26** (20060101); **H03K19/0175** (20060101); **H04R3/04** (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC **H03F3/217** (20130101); **H03F3/45479** (20130101); **H03K4/06** (20130101); **H03K5/26** (20130101); **H03K19/017509** (20130101); **H04R3/04** (20130101); H03F2200/03 (20130101); H04R2499/13 (20130101)

Field of Classification Search

CPC: H03F (3/217); H03F (3/45479); H03K (4/06); H03K (5/26); H03K (19/017509); H04R (3/04)

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Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This application is a continuation under 35 U.S.C. § 120 of PCT/JP2021/031523, filed Aug. 27, 2021, which is incorporated herein reference, and which claimed priority to Japanese Application No. 2020-166165, filed Sep. 30, 2020, the entire content of which is also incorporated herein by reference.

BACKGROUND

1. Technical Field

(1) The present disclosure relates to an audio amplifier circuit that drives a speaker or headphones.

2. Description of the Related Art

(2) As a power amplifier that drives an electroacoustic conversion element such as a speaker, headphones, or the like, a high-efficiency class D amplifier is employed. FIG. 1 is a block diagram

showing an audio system **100R** employing such a class D amplifier. The audio system **100R** mainly includes a speaker **102**, a low pass filter **104**, and an audio circuit **900R**.

(3) The audio circuit **900R** includes a class D amplifier circuit **200R**. The class D amplifier circuit **200R** generates an output pulse signal S.sub.OUT having a duty cycle that corresponds to an analog audio signal V.sub.IN. The low-pass filter **104** removes high-frequency components of the output pulse signal S.sub.OUT of the class D amplifier circuit **200R** and supplies the output pulse signal S.sub.OUT to the speaker **102**.

(4) The class D amplifier circuit **200R** is configured as a class D amplifier with a feedback function including an integrator **210**, a periodic voltage generating circuit **220**, a Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) comparator **230**, and a bridge circuit **240**.

(5) The integrator **210** includes resistors R11 and R12, a capacitor C11, and an error amplifier **212**. Regarding the inverting input terminal (−) of the error amplifier **212**, the analog audio signal V.sub.IN is input via the first resistor R11, and a feedback signal V.sub.FB that corresponds to the output pulse signal S.sub.OUT is input via the second resistor R12. The capacitor C11 is provided between the output and the inverting input terminal of the error amplifier **212**. Furthermore, a reference voltage V.sub.COM is input to the non-inverting input terminal of the error amplifier **212**. The gain g.sub.D of the class D amplifier circuit **200R** is represented by $R12/R11$.

(6) The periodic voltage generating circuit **220** generates a periodic voltage V.sub.OSC having a triangle waveform or otherwise a sawtooth waveform. The periodic voltage V.sub.OSC is configured as a pulse width modulation carrier wave. The periodic voltage V.sub.OSC has a PWM frequency that is higher than the audible frequency band (20 Hz to 20 kHz) and is determined in a range of several hundred kHz to several MHz. The PWM comparator **230** compares the output signal V.sub.INT of the integrator **210** with the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC and generates a PWM signal S.sub.PWM that switches between the high level and the low level according to the comparison result.

(7) The driver **250** switches a high-side transistor MH and a low-side transistor ML in a complementary manner according to the PWM signal S.sub.PWM. The driver **250** inserts dead time such that the high-side transistor MH and the low-side transistor ML do not turn on at the same time.

(8) With the audio circuit **900R** shown in FIG. 1, the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC generated by the periodic voltage generating circuit **220** has a fixed amplitude regardless of the power supply voltage V.sub.CC.

(9) It is necessary to design the voltage range of the output voltage V.sub.INT of the integrator **210** such that it is included in a range between the peak and the bottom of the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC. Accordingly, the maximum amplitude $\Delta V_{sub.MAX}$ of the analog audio signal V.sub.IN is restricted by the amplitude $\Delta V_{sub.OSC}$ of the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC. Specifically, the amplitude $\Delta V_{sub.OSC}$ of the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC is fixed to on the order of 2 Vpp, for example. Furthermore, the analog audio signal V.sub.IN is determined to have a center level VBIAS of 2.5 V and a maximum amplitude $\Delta V_{sub.MAX}$ of 5 Vpp.

(10) In a case in which the audio circuit **900R** shown in FIG. 1 is employed in a system with a large power supply voltage V.sub.CC, i.e., with the output pulse signal S.sub.OUT having a large amplitude, such an arrangement is not able to use the input voltage V.sub.IN having such a large amplitude (signal level) due to the restriction of the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC.

(11) Furthermore, with the audio system **100R**, in order to provide full-scale output, the class D amplifier **200R** must be designed such that it has a gain g of $V_{sub.CC}/\Delta V_{sub.MAX}$. In a case in which $V_{sub.CC}=15$ V, and $\Delta V_{sub.MAX}=5$ V, the integrator **210** must be designed with a gain g of 3. However, in a case in which the gain g is large, this leads to degraded noise characteristics.

SUMMARY

(12) The present disclosure has been made in order to solve the problems described above.

(13) An audio circuit according to the present disclosure includes: a class D amplifier circuit

structured to receive an analog audio signal with a first reference voltage as a center level, and to output an output pulse signal having a duty cycle that corresponds to the analog audio signal; and a bias circuit structured to generate a second reference voltage having a voltage level obtained by dividing the first reference voltage and a power supply voltage. The class D amplifier circuit includes: an integrator structured to receive the analog audio signal and a feedback signal that corresponds to the output pulse signal; a periodic voltage generating circuit structured to generate a periodic voltage having a triangle waveform or a sawtooth waveform; a Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) comparator structured to compare an output of the integrator with the periodic voltage; a bridge circuit structured to receive a supply of the power supply voltage; and a driver structured to drive the bridge circuit according to an output of the PWM comparator. The integrator includes: a first operational amplifier structured to receive the second reference voltage via a non-inverting input terminal; a first resistor structured such that the analog audio signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier; and a second resistor structured such that the feedback signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to the inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier. The periodic voltage generating circuit generates a periodic voltage having an amplitude that corresponds to the second reference voltage.

(14) It should be noted that any combination of the components described above, or any manifestation of the present invention may be mutually substituted between a method, apparatus and so forth, which are also effective as an embodiment of the present invention. The description of the items (means for solving the problems) is by no means intended to describe all the indispensable features of the present invention. That is to say, any sub-combination of the features as described above is also encompassed in the technical scope of the present invention.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) Embodiments will now be described, by way of example only, with reference to the accompanying drawings which are meant to be exemplary, not limiting, and wherein like elements are numbered alike in several Figures, in which:

(2) FIG. 1 is a block diagram showing an audio system employing a class D amplifier;

(3) FIG. 2 is a block diagram showing an audio system provided with an audio circuit according to an embodiment;

(4) FIGS. 3A through 3E are diagrams for explaining the operation of the audio circuit shown in FIG. 2;

(5) FIG. 4 is a circuit diagram showing an example configuration of a bias circuit;

(6) FIG. 5 is a circuit diagram showing an example configuration of a periodic voltage generating circuit;

(7) FIG. 6 is a diagram showing an example configuration of an audio circuit;

(8) FIG. 7 is a diagram showing another example configuration of the audio circuit;

(9) FIG. 8 is a block diagram showing an in-vehicle audio system employing an audio circuit according to an embodiment; and

(10) FIGS. 9A and 9B are diagrams each showing an electronic device employing an audio circuit according to an embodiment.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

Outline of Embodiments

(11) Description will be made regarding the outline of several exemplary embodiments of the present disclosure. The outline is a simplified explanation regarding several concepts of one or multiple embodiments as a prelude to the detailed description described later in order to provide a

basic understanding of the embodiments. That is to say, the outline described below is by no means intended to restrict the scope of the present invention and the present disclosure. Furthermore, the outline described below is by no means a comprehensive outline of all the possible embodiments. That is to say, the outline described below by no means restricts essential components of the embodiments. For convenience, in some cases, an “embodiment” as used in the present specification represents a single or multiple embodiments (examples and modifications) disclosed in the present specification.

(12) An audio circuit according to one embodiment includes: a class D amplifier circuit structured to receive an analog audio signal with a first reference voltage as a center level, and to output an output pulse signal having a duty cycle that corresponds to the analog audio signal; and a bias circuit structured to generate a second reference voltage having a voltage level obtained by dividing the first reference voltage and a power supply voltage. The class D amplifier circuit includes: an integrator structured to receive the analog audio signal and a feedback signal that corresponds to the output pulse signal; a periodic voltage generating circuit structured to generate a periodic voltage having a triangle waveform or a sawtooth waveform; a Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) comparator structured to compare an output of the integrator with the periodic voltage; a bridge circuit structured to receive a supply of the power supply voltage; and a driver structured to drive the bridge circuit according to an output of the PWM comparator. The integrator includes: a first operational amplifier structured to receive the second reference voltage via a non-inverting input terminal; a first resistor structured such that the analog audio signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier; and a second resistor structured such that the feedback signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to the inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier. The periodic voltage generating circuit generates a periodic voltage having an amplitude that corresponds to the second reference voltage.

(13) With this configuration, the second reference voltage supplied to the integrator changes according to the power supply voltage. Furthermore, the amplitude of the periodic voltage, which is employed as a pulse width modulation carrier wave, also changes according to the second reference voltage. As a result, this provides an improved degree of freedom in the design of the signal level of the analog audio signal.

(14) In one embodiment, the signal level (center level and maximum amplitude) of the analog audio signal may be set so as to be proportional to the power supply voltage. In this case, this allows the gain of the class D amplifier circuit to be maintained at a constant value regardless of the power supply voltage.

(15) Also, in one embodiment, in a case in which the power supply voltage is high, the signal level (center level and maximum amplitude) of the analog audio signal may be increased so as to set the gain of the class D amplifier circuit to a low value. With this, such an arrangement is capable of suppressing degradation of noise characteristics.

(16) In one embodiment, the periodic voltage generating circuit may include: a clock generating circuit structured to generate a first clock signal with an amplitude having a voltage level that is twice that of the second reference voltage; and a triangle wave generating circuit structured to generate the periodic voltage based on the first clock signal. With this, such an arrangement is capable of generating a triangle wave with the second reference voltage as the center level.

(17) In one embodiment, the clock generating circuit may include: a level shift circuit structured to receive a second clock signal having a frequency that is twice that of the periodic voltage, and to shift a high level voltage of the second clock signal to a voltage level that is twice that of the second reference voltage; and a frequency divider structured to divide the frequency of a third clock signal level-shifted by the level shift circuit by 2, so as to generate the first clock signal. With this, such an arrangement allows the duty cycle of the first clock signal to be maintained at 50%, thereby providing improved waveform quality of the triangle wave.

(18) In one embodiment, the frequency divider may include a flip-flop.

(19) In one embodiment, the triangle wave generating circuit may include: a second operational amplifier; a third resistor structured such that the first clock signal is received via one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the second operational amplifier; a first capacitor provided between an output terminal of the second operational amplifier and the inverting input terminal of the second operational amplifier; a third operational amplifier structured such that the second reference voltage is received via a non-inverting input terminal thereof, and an output terminal thereof is coupled to a non-inverting input terminal of the second operational amplifier; a fourth resistor structured such that one end thereof is coupled to the output terminal of the second operational amplifier, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the third operational amplifier; and a second capacitor provided between an output terminal of the third operational amplifier and the inverting input terminal of the third operational amplifier. The output voltage of the second operational amplifier may be employed as the periodic voltage. With this configuration, the voltage supplied to the non-inverting input terminal of the second operational amplifier is adjusted such that the center level of the periodic voltage approaches the second reference voltage. As a result, this is capable of suppressing characteristics degradation due to variation in the output impedance of the clock generating circuit and fluctuation of the power supply voltage.

(20) In one embodiment, the bias circuit may include: a first voltage dividing circuit structured to generate a midpoint voltage that is $\frac{1}{2}$ times the power supply voltage; and a second voltage dividing circuit structured to divide the first reference voltage and the midpoint voltage.

(21) In one embodiment, the second voltage dividing circuit may have a voltage dividing ratio that is equal to the gain of the class D amplifier circuit. This allows the class D amplifier circuit to be operated at an optimum operating point that corresponds to the power supply voltage.

(22) In one embodiment, the audio circuit may be monolithically integrated on a single substrate. Examples of such an “integrated” arrangement include: an arrangement in which all the circuit components are formed on a substrate; and an arrangement in which principal circuit components are monolithically integrated. Also, a part of the circuit components such as resistors or capacitors may be arranged in the form of components external to such a substrate in order to adjust the circuit constants. By integrating the circuit on a single chip, such an arrangement allows the circuit area to be reduced and allows the circuit elements to have uniform characteristics.

Embodiments

(23) Description will be made below regarding preferred embodiments with reference to the drawings. The same or similar components, members, and processes are denoted by the same reference numerals, and redundant description thereof will be omitted as appropriate. The embodiments have been described for exemplary purposes only and are by no means intended to restrict the present disclosure or the present invention. Also, it is not necessarily essential for the present disclosure or the present invention that all the features or a combination thereof be provided as described in the embodiments.

(24) In the present specification, the state represented by the phrase “the member A is coupled to the member B” includes a state in which the member A is indirectly coupled to the member B via another member that does not affect the electrical connection between them, or that does not damage the functions of the connection between them, in addition to a state in which they are physically and directly coupled.

(25) Similarly, the state represented by the phrase “the member C is provided between the member A and the member B” includes a state in which the member A is indirectly coupled to the member B via the member C, or the member B is indirectly coupled to the member A via the member C, in addition to a state in which they are directly coupled.

(26) FIG. 2 is a block diagram showing an audio system **100** including an audio circuit **300**

according to an embodiment. The audio system **100** includes a speaker **102**, a low pass filter **104**, and an audio circuit **300**.

(27) The audio circuit **300** includes a class D amplifier circuit **200** and a bias circuit **310** and is integrated on a single semiconductor chip configured as a function IC (integrated circuit). An external power supply voltage V.sub.CC is supplied to a power supply pin VCC of the audio circuit **300**.

(28) The class D amplifier circuit **200** receives an input of an analog audio signal V.sub.IN with a first reference voltage V.sub.FIL as its center level. The class D amplifier circuit **200** generates an output pulse signal S.sub.OUT having a duty cycle that corresponds to the analog audio signal V.sub.IN. The low-pass filter **104** removes high-frequency components of the output pulse signal S.sub.OUT of the class D amplifier circuit **200** and supplies the output pulse signal S.sub.OUT to the speaker **102**.

(29) The first reference voltage V.sub.FIL (or a voltage that is proportional to the first reference voltage V.sub.FIL) and the power supply voltage V.sub.CC (or a voltage that is proportional to the power supply voltage V.sub.CC) are supplied to the bias circuit **310**. The bias circuit **310** generates a second reference voltage V.sub.FILP obtained by dividing the first reference voltage V.sub.FIL and the power supply voltage V.sub.CC.

(30) The class D amplifier circuit **200** is configured as a class D amplifier with a feedback function, including an integrator **210**, a periodic voltage generating circuit **260**, a Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) comparator **230**, and a bridge circuit **240**.

(31) The integrator **210** includes resistors R11 and R12, a capacitor C11, and an error amplifier **212**. Regarding the inverting input terminal (−) of the error amplifier **212**, the analog audio signal V.sub.IN is input via the first resistor R11, and a feedback signal V.sub.FB that corresponds to the output pulse signal S.sub.OUT is input via the second resistor R12. The capacitor C11 is provided between the output and the inverting input terminal of the error amplifier **212**. The second reference voltage V.sub.FILP is input to the non-inverting input terminal of the error amplifier **212**. The gain go of the class D amplifier circuit **200** is represented by R12/R11.

(32) The class D amplifier circuit **200** is configured to have a variable gain. Also, the class D amplifier circuit **200** may be configured to allow the designer of the audio system **100** to freely change the gain to a desired value.

(33) Preferably, the second reference voltage V.sub.FILP is generated so as to satisfy the following Expression.

$$V_{\text{sub.FILP}} = (V_{\text{sub.CC}}/2 \times R12 + V_{\text{sub.FIL}} \times R11) / (R11 + R12)$$

(34) The periodic voltage generating circuit **260** generates a periodic voltage V.sub.OSC having a triangle waveform or otherwise a sawtooth waveform. The periodic voltage V.sub.OSC is configured as a pulse width modulation carrier wave. The periodic voltage V.sub.OSC has a PWM frequency that is higher than the audible frequency band (20 Hz to 20 kHz) and is determined in a range of several hundred kHz to several MHz.

(35) The PWM comparator **230** compares the output signal V.sub.INT of the integrator **210** with the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC and generates a PWM signal S.sub.PWM that switches between the high level and the low level according to the comparison result.

(36) The bridge circuit **240** is configured as a push-pull inverter and receives the supply of the power supply voltage V.sub.CC. The bridge circuit **240** includes a high-side transistor MH and a low-side transistor ML. The high-side transistor MH may be configured as a PMOS transistor or an NMOS transistor.

(37) The driver **250** switches the high-side transistor MH and the low-side transistor ML of the bridge circuit **240** in a complementary manner according to the PWM signal S.sub.PWM. The driver **250** inserts dead time such that the high-side transistor MH and the low-side transistor ML do not turn on at the same time.

(38) The periodic voltage generating circuit **260** receives the supply of the second reference voltage

V.sub.FILP. The periodic voltage generating circuit **260** generates the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC having a peak-to-peak amplitude $\Delta V_{\text{sub.OSC}}$ that corresponds to the second reference voltage V.sub.FLIP. For example, the amplitude $\Delta V_{\text{sub.OSC}}$ may be designed to be $V_{\text{sub.CC}}/N$ (N represents a constant). For example, an arrangement may be made in which $N=4$.

(39) The above is the configuration of the audio circuit **300**. Next, description will be made regarding the operation thereof. FIGS. **3A** through **3E** are diagrams for explaining the operation of the audio circuit **300** shown in FIG. **2**. FIGS. **3A** through **3E** show different combinations of the power supply voltage V.sub.CC, the gain of the class D amplifier circuit **200**, and the signal level of the analog audio signal V.sub.IN.

(40) For ease of understanding, FIGS. **3A** and **3C** each show an example in which $V_{\text{sub.CC}}=10$ V, and FIGS. **3B**, **3D**, and **3E** each show an example in which $V_{\text{sub.CC}}=15$ V. Furthermore, FIGS. **3A** and **3B** each show an example in which $V_{\text{sub.FIL}}=2.5$ V, FIGS. **3C** and **3D** each show an example in which $V_{\text{sub.FIL}}=5$ V, and FIG. **3E** shows an example in which $V_{\text{sub.FIL}}=7.5$ V. FIGS. **3A** through **3E** show examples in which the gain is set to 2, 3, 1, 1.5, and 1, respectively.

(41) In the examples shown in FIGS. **3A** through **3E**, the second reference voltage V.sub.FILP, which is employed as the center level of the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC, is set to 4.17 V, 6.25 V, 5 V, 6.5 V, and 7.5 V, respectively. Furthermore, in FIGS. **3A** through **3E**, the peak-to-peak amplitude $\Delta V_{\text{sub.OSC}}$ of the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC is $\frac{1}{4}$ times the power supply voltage V.sub.CC, which is set to 2.5 V, 3.75 V, 2.5 V, 3.75 V, and 3.5 V, respectively. In all cases, the analog audio signal V.sub.IN can be amplified in full scale to drive the speaker **102**.

(42) As described above, with the audio circuit **300** according to the present embodiment, this allows flexible design of the signal level according to the power supply voltage V.sub.CC.

(43) For example, as shown in FIGS. **3C** and **3E**, this allows the signal level (center level and maximum amplitude) of the analog audio signal V.sub.IN to be set so as to be proportional to the power supply voltage V.sub.CC. In this case, such an arrangement allows the class D amplifier circuit **200** to have a constant gain regardless of the power supply voltage V.sub.CC.

(44) Furthermore, as shown in FIGS. **3C**, **3E**, and **3D**, in a case in which the power supply voltage V.sub.CC is high, by increasing the signal level (center level and maximum amplitude) of the analog audio signal V.sub.IN, such an arrangement allows the gain of the class D amplifier circuit **200** to be set to a small value. With this, such an arrangement provides improved noise characteristics as compared with a case in which the class D amplifier circuit **200** has a high gain (e.g., 3).

(45) Also, the signal level of the analog audio signal V.sub.IN may be determined according to the setting value of the volume. With this, such an arrangement is capable of providing full-scale output according to various volumes.

(46) The present disclosure encompasses various kinds of circuits that can be regarded as a circuit configuration shown in FIG. **2**, or otherwise that can be derived from the aforementioned description. That is to say, the present invention is not restricted to a specific configuration. Specific description will be made below regarding examples for clarification and ease of understanding of the essence of the present invention and the circuit operation. That is to say, the following description will by no means be intended to restrict the technical scope of the present invention.

(47) FIG. **4** is a circuit diagram showing an example configuration of the bias circuit **310**. The bias circuit **310** includes resistors R23 through R26, and buffers **313** and **314**.

(48) The fifth resistor R25, the sixth resistor R26, and the buffer **313** form a first voltage dividing circuit **316** that divides the power supply voltage V.sub.CC. In a case in which $R25=R26$, the voltage dividing circuit **316** generates a midpoint voltage $V_{\text{sub.CC}}/2$ of the power supply voltage V.sub.CC, and outputs the midpoint voltage $V_{\text{sub.CC}}/2$ via the buffer **313**.

(49) The third resistor R23 and the fourth resistor R24 are provided between the output of the voltage dividing circuit **316** and a node (line) FIL at which the first reference voltage V.sub.FIL

occurs and form a second voltage dividing circuit **317**.

(50) The resistance value ratio between the third resistor **R23** and the fourth resistor **R24** may be determined according to the gain $g_{sub.D}$ of the class D amplifier circuit **200**, i.e., the resistance values of the first resistor **R11** and the second resistor **R12** shown in FIG. 2.

$$R24:R23=R11:R12$$

(51) A voltage V_x , which is obtained as an internal division of the voltage $V_{sub.CC}/2$ and the voltage $V_{sub.FIL}$, occurs at a coupling node N_x that couples the third resistor **R23** and the fourth resistor **R24**.

$$V_x=(V_{sub.FIL} \times R23 + V_{sub.CC}/2 \times R24)/(R23 + R24)$$

(52) The buffer **314** has a high input impedance and a low output impedance. The buffer **314** outputs the second reference voltage $V_{sub.FILP}$ having the same voltage level as that of the voltage V_x .

(53) FIG. 5 is a circuit diagram showing an example configuration of the periodic voltage generating circuit **260**. The periodic voltage generating circuit **260** includes a clock generating circuit **262** and a triangle wave generating circuit **264**.

(54) The clock generating circuit **262** generates a first clock signal **CLK1** with an amplitude having a voltage level ($2 \times V_{sub.FILP}$) that is twice that of the second reference voltage $V_{sub.FILP}$. The triangle wave generating circuit **264** generates the periodic voltage $V_{sub.OSC}$ based on the first clock signal **CLK1**.

(55) A voltage source **266** generates a voltage level ($2 \times V_{sub.FILP}$) that is twice the second reference voltage $V_{sub.FILP}$. A level shift circuit **268** receives an input of a second clock signal **CLK2** having a frequency that is twice that of the periodic voltage $V_{sub.OSC}$. The level shift circuit **268** shifts the level of the high-level voltage of the second clock signal **CLK2** (e.g., power supply voltage $V_{sub.DD}$) to the voltage level ($2 \times V_{sub.FILP}$) that is twice the second reference voltage $V_{sub.FILP}$.

(56) A frequency divider **270** divides the frequency of the third clock signal **CLK3** level-shifted by the level shift circuit **268** by 2, so as to generate the first clock signal **CLK1**. For example, the frequency divider **270** may be configured as a flip-flop. In some cases, the duty cycle of the clock output from the level shift circuit **268** deviates from 50% due to the clock signal passing through the level shift circuit **268**, or due to fluctuation of the power supply voltage. With the clock generating circuit **262** shown in FIG. 5, the second clock signal **CLK2** having a frequency that is twice the final frequency is input to the level shift circuit **268**. Subsequently, after the level of the second clock signal **CLK2** is shifted, the frequency of the clock signal **CLK2** is divided by 2, thereby allowing the duty cycle of the first clock signal **CLK1** to be maintained at 50%. This provides improved quality of the triangle waveform, thereby providing improved modulation precision.

(57) Next, description will be made regarding an example configuration of the triangle wave generating circuit **264**. The triangle wave generating circuit **264** includes operational amplifiers **OA31** and **OA32**, resistors **R31** and **R32**, and capacitors **C31** and **C32**. The resistor **R31** is arranged such that it receives the first clock signal **CLK1** via its one end, and the other end thereof is coupled to the inverting input terminal (-) of the operational amplifier **OA31**. The capacitor **C31** is provided between the output terminal and the inverting input terminal (-) of the operational amplifier **OA31**.

(58) The second reference voltage $V_{sub.FILP}$ is input to the non-inverting input terminal of the operational amplifier **OA32**. The output terminal of the operational amplifier **OA32** is coupled to the non-inverting input terminal (+) of the operational amplifier **OA31**. One end of the resistor **R32** is coupled to the output terminal of the operational amplifier **OA31**. The other end thereof is coupled to the inverting input terminal of the operational amplifier **OA32**. The capacitor **C32** is provided between the output terminal and the inverting input terminal of the operational amplifier **OA32**. The output voltage of the operational amplifier **OA31** is employed as the periodic voltage

V.sub.OSC.

(59) With this configuration, the voltage supplied to the non-inverting input terminal of the operational amplifier OA**31** is adjusted such that the center level of the periodic voltage V.sub.OSC approaches the second reference voltage V.sub.FLIP. As a result, such an arrangement is capable of suppressing characteristics degradation due to variation in the output impedance of the clock generating circuit **262** and fluctuation of the power supply voltage.

(60) Next, description will be made regarding the input interface of the audio circuit **300**.

(61) FIG. **6** is a diagram showing an example configuration (**300A**) of the audio circuit **300**. The audio circuit **300A** includes an interface circuit **330** and a D/A converter **320** in addition to the bias circuit **310** and the class D amplifier circuit **200**.

(62) The digital audio interface circuit **330** receives a digital audio signal S.sub.DIG from an external sound source. The format of the digital audio signal S.sub.DIG is not restricted in particular. Examples of the format of the digital audio signal S.sub.DIG include Inter IC Sound (I.sup.2S), etc.

(63) The D/A converter **320** converts the digital audio signal S.sub.DIG received by the digital audio interface circuit **330** into an analog audio signal V.sub.IN.

(64) With this configuration, the center level V.sub.FIL of the analog audio signal V.sub.IN is determined according to the reference voltage V.sub.REF of the D/A converter **320**. Accordingly, the first reference voltage V.sub.FIL having a voltage level based on the reference voltage V.sub.REF may preferably be supplied to the bias circuit **310**.

(65) FIG. **7** is a diagram showing another example configuration (**300B**) of the audio circuit **300**. The audio circuit **300B** includes an analog input interface circuit **340** in addition to the bias circuit **310** and the class D amplifier circuit **200**. The analog input interface circuit **340** includes a resistor R**41** provided between the analog input pin IN and a node at which the first reference voltage V.sub.FIL occurs. An analog audio signal S.sub.ANLG is input to the analog input pin IN via a coupling capacitor. In this case, the first reference voltage V.sub.FIL may preferably be supplied to the bias circuit **310**.

Usage

(66) Description will be made regarding the usage of the audio circuit **300**. FIG. **8** is a block diagram showing an in-vehicle audio system employing the audio circuit according to the embodiment.

(67) An in-vehicle audio system **500** includes four speakers **502.sub.FL**, **502.sub.FR**, **502.sub.RL**, and **502.sub.RR**, four filters **504.sub.FL**, **504.sub.FR**, **504.sub.RL**, and **504.sub.RR**, a sound source **506**, and an audio circuit **300**.

(68) The sound source **106** outputs a left-and-right (LR) two-channel or multi-channel digital audio signal. The audio circuit **300** includes a four-channel class D amplifier circuit **200** and an interface circuit **301** for communicating with the sound source **106**. The interface circuit **301** can be regarded as the digital interface circuit **330** and the D/A converter **320** shown in FIG. **3**.

(69) The filter **504**, the sound source **506**, and the audio circuit **300** are built into an audio head unit or a car navigation apparatus. Alternatively, the audio circuit **300** may be a product independent of the sound source **106**.

(70) FIGS. **9A** and **9B** are diagrams each showing an electronic device employing the audio circuit according to the embodiment. The electronic device shown in FIG. **9A** is a display apparatus **600** such as a TV, etc. The display apparatus **600** includes speakers **602L** and **602R**, filters **604L** and **604R**, a sound source **606**, an audio circuit **300**, and a display panel **610**.

(71) The electronic device shown in FIG. **9B** is an audio component apparatus **800**. The audio component apparatus **800** includes an audio signal processing circuit **806** that corresponds to a sound source, an audio circuit **300**, and an unshown filter. The audio circuit **300** drives speakers **802L** and **802R** coupled via speaker cables.

(72) The above-described embodiments have been described for exemplary purposes only. Rather,

it can be readily conceived by those skilled in this art that various modifications may be made by making various combinations of the aforementioned components or processes. Description will be made below regarding such modifications.

(73) Description has been made in the embodiment regarding an example employing a half-bridge type class D amplifier. Also, the present invention is applicable to a full-bridge type (BTL: Bridge-Tied Load) class D amplifier. In this case, the DC block capacitor of the low pass filter **104** becomes unnecessary. Furthermore, with the full-bridge type class D amplifier, a filterless modulation method may be employed in which the low-pass filter **104** is omitted.

Claims

1. An audio circuit comprising: a class D amplifier circuit structured to receive an analog audio signal with a first reference voltage as a center level, and to output an output pulse signal having a duty cycle that corresponds to the analog audio signal; and a bias circuit structured to generate a second reference voltage having a voltage level obtained by dividing the first reference voltage and a power supply voltage, wherein the class D amplifier circuit comprises: an integrator structured to receive the analog audio signal and a feedback signal that corresponds to the output pulse signal; a periodic voltage generating circuit structured to generate a periodic voltage having a triangle waveform or a sawtooth waveform; a Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) comparator structured to compare an output of the integrator with the periodic voltage; a bridge circuit structured to receive a supply of the power supply voltage; and a driver structured to drive the bridge circuit according to an output of the PWM comparator, wherein the integrator comprises: a first operational amplifier structured to receive the second reference voltage via a non-inverting input terminal; a first resistor structured such that the analog audio signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier; and a second resistor structured such that the feedback signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to the inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier, and wherein the periodic voltage generating circuit generates a periodic voltage having an amplitude that corresponds to the second reference voltage, wherein the periodic voltage generating circuit comprises: a clock generating circuit structured to generate a first clock signal with an amplitude having a voltage level that is twice that of the second reference voltage; and a triangle wave generating circuit structured to generate the periodic voltage based on the first clock signal.
2. The audio circuit according to claim 1, wherein the clock generating circuit comprises: a level shift circuit structured to receive a second clock signal having a frequency that is twice that of the periodic voltage, and to shift a high level voltage of the second clock signal to a voltage level that is twice that of the second reference voltage; and a frequency divider structured to divide a frequency of a third clock signal level-shifted by the level shift circuit by 2, so as to generate the first clock signal.
3. The audio circuit according to claim 2, wherein the frequency divider comprises a flip-flop.
4. The audio circuit according to claim 1, wherein the triangle wave generating circuit comprises: a second operational amplifier; a third resistor structured such that the first clock signal is received via one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the second operational amplifier; a first capacitor provided between an output terminal of the second operational amplifier and the inverting input terminal of the second operational amplifier; a third operational amplifier structured such that the second reference voltage is received via a non-inverting input terminal thereof, and an output terminal thereof is coupled to a non-inverting input terminal of the second operational amplifier; a fourth resistor structured such that one end thereof is coupled to the output terminal of the second operational amplifier, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the third operational amplifier; and a second capacitor provided between an output terminal of the third operational amplifier and the inverting input

terminal of the third operational amplifier, and wherein an output voltage of the second operational amplifier is employed as the periodic voltage.

5. The audio circuit according to claim 1, monolithically integrated on a single substrate.

6. An in-vehicle audio system comprising: a speaker; and the audio circuit according to claim 1, structured to drive the speaker.

7. An electronic device provided with the audio circuit according to claim 1.

8. An audio circuit comprising: a class D amplifier circuit structured to receive an analog audio signal with a first reference voltage as a center level, and to output an output pulse signal having a duty cycle that corresponds to the analog audio signal; and a bias circuit structured to generate a second reference voltage having a voltage level obtained by dividing the first reference voltage and a power supply voltage, wherein the class D amplifier circuit comprises: an integrator structured to receive the analog audio signal and a feedback signal that corresponds to the output pulse signal; a periodic voltage generating circuit structured to generate a periodic voltage having a triangle waveform or a sawtooth waveform; a Pulse Width Modulation (PWM) comparator structured to compare an output of the integrator with the periodic voltage; a bridge circuit structured to receive a supply of the power supply voltage; and a driver structured to drive the bridge circuit according to an output of the PWM comparator, wherein the integrator comprises: a first operational amplifier structured to receive the second reference voltage via a non-inverting input terminal; a first resistor structured such that the analog audio signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to an inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier; and a second resistor structured such that the feedback signal is input to one end thereof, and the other end thereof is coupled to the inverting input terminal of the first operational amplifier, and wherein the periodic voltage generating circuit generates a periodic voltage having an amplitude that corresponds to the second reference voltage, wherein the bias circuit comprises: a first voltage dividing circuit structured to generate a midpoint voltage that is $\frac{1}{2}$ times the power supply voltage; and a second voltage dividing circuit structured to divide the first reference voltage and the midpoint voltage, wherein the second voltage dividing circuit has a voltage dividing ratio that is equal to a gain of the class D amplifier circuit.
